dit families left the Valley, mainly for Jammu. Jagmohan was asked to resign and Girish Chandra Saxena, a former police officer, took over. It would take several years to bring the security situation under control. Barely 700 families remained. While official records say 219 Pandits were killed, the KPSS, which recently conducted a systematic survey of all those who were killed, puts the number at a little less than 700.

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE NOW?

If one thought the flight of Pandits would mark the end of strife in Kashmir, it was not to be. Between 1990 and 2000, the state saw over 45,000 people being killed, of which 22,500 were terrorists, 6,000 security personnel and as many as 17,000 civilians. These horrifying numbers do not in any way diminish the magnitude of the tragedy or the wrongs done to Pandits. What hasn't helped is the apathy of successive governments toward their rehabilitation. A majority of the Pandits had migrated to Jammu where they lived in makeshift quarters—mostly tents on the outskirts of the city—for several years. Cash and food relief was provided regularly (see *Tracking the Exodus*), but for a once-prosperous people, living on alms was a blow to their pride. Only in 2004, when the Manmohan Singh government came to power, did the Centre make any effort, building townships for Pandits in Jammu with pucca houses and also initiating the process of their return to the Valley by providing for 3,000 jobs and transit accommodation. In 2015, the Modi government added another 3,000 jobs to the list and is building 6,000 transit accommodation units for them in 19 locations. "We will ensure speedy implementation of these commitments," says Nazim Zai Khan, secretary, disaster management, relief, rehabilitation and reconstruction.

With native enterprise and determination, as well as a focus on their children's education, the Pandits largely dug themselves out of the holes they found themselves in and began to thrive again. When the Mufti, as chief minister, met a delegation of Pandits, he famously told them, "*Aap aabaad ho gaye, hum barbaad ho gaye* (You have become prosperous, we have been ruined)." Having found their feet, the Pandits' earlier inhibitions about speaking out against the atrocities they faced seem to be diminishing. They are no longer a weak or disempowered community. *The Kashmir Files* has touched a chord that has resuscitated cries for justice and closure. Their representatives, though, are divided on how to go about it. Mattoo says, "One reason they would want a balanced approach is that unlike the Jews after the Holocaust, who got an independent nation-state, the Pandits will have to go back and live with the Muslims. So, if the Muslims recognise that mistakes were made and the Pandits do not outright condemn them, there is a way to find space together."

> Some recommend separate enclaves for Pandits in the Valley, but the fear is **it will create a Palestine-like situation** of constant tension

The other way is what Panun Kashmir, a prominent Kashmiri Pandit organisation, is advocating. To have special protected enclaves for Pandits in the Valley so that they can return with confidence. Kshama Kaul, a well-known Hindi author who has written several books on the plight of the Pandits and whose daughter acted in *The Kashmir Files*, says, "We are not just 6,000 Pandits, we are 5 lakh of us. So, the government should carve out a settlement for Pandits in a few districts of the Valley and we can move there." The argument being, if Pandits go back individually to the Valley, they would be, as Sushil Pandit puts it, "like lambs to the slaughter". According to him, "We need to go as a community and live in one part of Kashmir. In agricultural terms, it is like consolidating land holdings. So, Pandit properties all over the Valley could be consolidated into one place and, depending on the size, the number of districts could be carved out." Not all are convinced. They fear it will create a Palestine-like situation in Kashmir where both communities will live amid constant tension. Instead, the government is thinking of building special enclaves for Pandits along with ones for army and security officers, so that they have adequate protection.

There are others who feel that the younger Kashmiri, who is not weighed down by the memories or experience of living in the Valley, may not want to go back to Kashmir and instead find their fortunes elsewhere in the country or abroad. Especially because Kashmir is still plagued by security issues and a dearth of economic opportunity. Lt Governor Manoj Sinha, while pushing for zero militancy, says he is addressing the jobs crisis by inviting industry to come and set up shop in the Valley. Only last week, he held one such meeting where businessmen from the UAE were invited to invest.

While these are steps in the right direction, they will require time to fructify. What most Pandits seek is punishment for those who perpetrated the violence against them. That Yasin Malik and Bitta Karate have not been convicted for lack of evidence rankles. "People are too scared to come forward and give evidence against terrorists for fear of reprisal," says a senior official. "So our track record of conviction is poor." It is the reason why Sushil Pandit says his organisation is pushing the government to term their experience as genocide. It would require the establishment of special courts where the evidence requirements are different and individual testimonies are accepted. Farooq Abdullah's proposal for a Truth Commission too has merit. It is important that the truth is out so that no Indian ever has to face the plight of the Kashmiri Pandit. It will also provide the community closure. ■